



Franz Beckenbauer

Winning the World Cup once is hard enough. Winning it as both a player and a manager is something only three people in history have done, and at the top of that elusive list sits Der Kaiser Franz Beckenbauer.

In an era that did not practice the refined version of the sport we know today, Beckenbauer emerged as a tactical leader for West Germany while also standing out for his grit on the pitch.

After losing to England in the 1966 final, he proved his toughness in the following edition, playing with one arm in a sling during West Germany's 3-4 semifinal defeat to Italy.

But battle only hardens the tough, and Beckenbauer reinvented himself as a libero, controlling the pitch as a spare man in attack while also shutting down gaps in defence. On home soil in 1974, under his calm leadership, West Germany secured its second title.

But the job was not done. The fight may have left his legs, but it remained in his mind as he took up a spot on the touchline, leading the nation to the final in 1986, where it was beaten by Maradona and Co.

However, he got his revenge and crowning moment in the 1990 final against Argentina, coaching West Germany to the title and becoming the first individual to lift the trophy as both captain and manager.

The first image that comes to mind for many when recalling Zinedine Zidane at the World Cup is his infamous headbutt on Marco Materazzi in the 2006 final. But his legacy had been established long before that spat.

For much of his first World Cup in 1998, Zidane was just a cog in the system. Adding to that a red card against Saudi Arabia in the group stage meant he missed two games before returning for the quarterfinals.

But, as it turned out, he was saving his best for last.

With zero goals and just one assist up until the final, Zizou turned up big time against the Brazilians, scoring two identical headers to hand France its maiden title.

Like many greats, injuries took a toll on his career, leaving him watching helplessly as France crashed out of the 2002 World Cup. Elimination at the hands of Greece at Euro 2004 prompted him to retire, only for him to return the following year and heroically lead France to the 2006 final.

In his last dance, Zidane rolled back the years and toyed with opponents, especially in the quarterfinal against a Brazil side packed with stars like Kaka, Ronaldinho and Ronaldo.

The final was a tale of two polarising incidents — starting the night with a panenka over Gianluigi Buffon and ending with him flooring Materazzi.

Two headers made him a World Champion, and a third one brought down the curtains on an illustrious journey. A fittingly dramatic end.



Zinedine Zidane